

Week 3: Bebop

Quiz Study Guide

MUS/AAS 262 — Jazz History: Many Sounds, Many Voices
The Bebop Revolution (1940–1950)

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1 Knowledge Tracker

Move items between sections as you study. The goal is to get everything into Green.

Green — Know From Memory

- ☐ Charlie Parker = “Bird”; heart and soul of bebop; called “everyone’s God” by Sonny Rollins
- ☐ Bebop began at Minton’s Playhouse and Clark Monroe’s Uptown House in Harlem

Yellow — Partial / Need Notes

- ☐ Recording ban (1942–1944) limited documentation of early bebop development
- ☐ “Playing the changes” = navigating complicated chord structures; became hallmark of bebop
- ☐ Upper extensions of chords = Parker heard how to connect these when jamming; gave him his sound
- ☐ Bebop as counterculture: fast-paced, NOT danceable, associated with zoot suits, horn-rimmed glasses, berets, goatees

Red — Didn’t Know / Got Wrong

- ☐ World War II significantly influenced bebop’s development (economic hardship + cultural darkness)
- ☐ Langston Hughes quote: “Every time a cop beats a black man with a bat, it makes a Bop sound. Bee, bop, bee, bop.”
- ☐ Small band groups (combos) replaced big bands due to economic constraints
- ☐ Big band musicians felt their music wasn’t being taken seriously; bebop was violent shift to “mad, furious” music
- ☐ Billy Eckstine’s 1944 big band featured Parker, Dizzy, Miles Davis, Art Blakey, Sarah Vaughan
- ☐ Parker made playing in all 12 keys standard for jazz artists
- ☐ Parker’s heroin addiction influenced a generation of musicians; he hated this legacy

Not Yet Tested

- ☐ Dizzy Gillespie (1917–1993) = public face of bebop; very jovial onstage but serious about music
- ☐ Dizzy: bullfrog cheeks when playing trumpet; upturned trumpet horn (accident became signature)
- ☐ Dizzy played really high on the trumpet
- ☐ Roy Eldridge = bridge between Armstrong and Dizzy; lead trumpeter for Fletcher Henderson
- ☐ Roy Eldridge: vibrato and accents make it sound like someone singing; hot trumpet sound like Armstrong
- ☐ Charlie Christian (guitarist): died at 25 of tuberculosis in 1942; first to bring electric guitar to jazz
- ☐ Charlie Christian: long flowing melodic lines; rhythm reminiscent of beginnings of bebop
- ☐ Kenny Clarke = first bebop drummer; drums driving the beat just like the guitar
- ☐ Art Tatum: legally blind; incredible technique, played very fast; stride piano technique

- ☐ Art Tatum: big influence on Bud Powell (pianist)
- ☐ Stride piano = alternating left hand technique
- ☐ Jimmy Blanton (bassist): died at 23; huge sound on bass; big figure in Ellington band
- ☐ Jimmy Blanton: “walking” bass line leading the band
- ☐ Lester Young: “cool sound” (contrast with Armstrong/Eldridge “hot sound”); one of Parker’s biggest influences
- ☐ Oscar Peterson: great pianist featured on 1952 “Ad Lib Blues” with Lester Young
- ☐ Max Roach: featured bebop drummer, represented evolution of bebop drumming
- ☐ Miles Davis played piano on Parker’s “Coco”
- ☐ 1988 film “Bird” by Clint Eastwood starring Forest Whitaker

2 The Era: Bebop (1940–1950)

2.1 What This Movement Contributes

1. **Small Group Revolution** — Shift from big bands to small combos (4–6 musicians) due to WWII economics and artistic rebellion
2. **Virtuosic Improvisation** — Extreme technical demands; fast tempos; complex chord progressions; “playing the changes”
3. **Art Music, Not Dance Music** — Bebop was for listening, not dancing; deliberate rejection of entertainment model
4. **Upper Extensions & Harmonic Complexity** — Use of 9ths, 11ths, 13ths in improvisation expanded harmonic vocabulary
5. **All 12 Keys Standard** — Charlie Parker made playing in all keys standard for jazz artists
6. **Counterculture Movement** — Bebop came with visual style (zoot suits, berets, goatees, horn-rimmed glasses) and cultural attitude

2.2 Era Characteristics

- **Historical Context:** World War II backdrop; economic hardship made big bands unsustainable; cultural darkness and anger
- **Rhythmic Feel:** Very fast tempos; pushing forward on the beat; drummer shifts timekeeping from bass drum to ride cymbal
- **Ensemble Style:** Small combos (trumpet/sax, piano, bass, drums); horns driving the music
- **Improvisation:** Extended solos with complex harmonic navigation; thinking over phrases that span whole measures
- **Melody:** Angular, unpredictable melodies with large intervallic leaps; syncopated, staccato phrasing
- **Sound:** Clear articulation even at extreme speeds; every note distinguishable
- **Recording Gap:** 1942–1944 recording ban limited documentation of bebop’s earliest development

2.3 Key Concepts

- **Bebop Origin:** Name comes from scatting sound; also Langston Hughes quote about police violence (“bee-bop, bee-bop”)
- **Minton’s Playhouse & Clark Monroe’s Uptown House:** Harlem clubs where bebop was born; later commercialized on 52nd Street
- **Playing the Changes:** Navigating complicated chord structures became hallmark of bebop
- **Upper Extensions:** 9ths, 11ths, 13ths of chords; Parker heard how to connect these when improvising
- **Stride Piano:** Alternating left hand technique (Art Tatum, precursor to bebop piano)
- **Walking Bass:** Bass line that moves steadily through chord changes, often in quarter notes
- **Recording Ban (1942–1944):** Musicians’ union strike against record labels limited early bebop documentation

- **Billy Eckstine's 1944 Band:** Featured Parker, Dizzy, Miles Davis, Art Blakey, Sarah Vaughan — bebop all-stars

2.4 Five Precursors Who Pushed Bebop Forward (1940s)

1. **Roy Eldridge** (trumpet): Bridge between Armstrong and Dizzy
2. **Charlie Christian** (guitar): First to bring electric guitar to jazz; long flowing melodic lines
3. **Art Tatum** (piano): Incredible technique, played very fast; stride piano; influenced Bud Powell
4. **Jimmy Blanton** (bass): Huge sound; walking bass lines; featured in Ellington band
5. **Lester Young** (saxophone): Cool sound; major influence on Charlie Parker

3 Artists and Songs — Syllabus Listening

3.1 Charlie Parker & Dizzy Gillespie — “Dizzy Atmosphere” (Live)

Era: Bebop (1940s)

from Diz N’ Bird at Carnegie Hall

Key Facts

1. Live recording showcasing both Parker (alto sax) and Dizzy Gillespie (trumpet)
2. Based on “I Got Rhythm” chord changes (contrafact)
3. Dizzy plays really high on the trumpet
4. Crazy technique — all notes clear and distinguishable even at extreme speed
5. Shorter phrases but still playing through them
6. Bass rhythm getting faster throughout
7. Demonstrates the virtuosity required for bebop performance

Instrumentation: Alto saxophone (Parker), trumpet (Dizzy), rhythm section (piano, bass, drums)

Song Form: 32-bar AABA (“I Got Rhythm” chord progression)

Listen For: Extremely fast tempo, Parker’s clear articulation at high speed, Dizzy’s high register playing, both horns driving the music, rhythm section pushing tempo forward, shorter phrases with quick runs, every note distinguishable despite speed

3.2 Charlie Parker — “Ko Ko” (1945)

Era: Bebop (1945)

from The Complete Savoy Recordings

Key Facts

1. Also based on “I Got Rhythm” chord changes (contrafact) but spelled “Ko Ko”
2. Features pre-composed introduction and ending
3. Miles Davis played piano on this recording
4. Demonstrates Parker’s ability to navigate complex chord changes at breakneck speed
5. Parker made playing in all 12 keys standard for jazz artists
6. Features Max Roach on drums — representing evolution of bebop drumming
7. One of the definitive bebop recordings

Instrumentation: Alto saxophone (Parker), trumpet, piano (Miles Davis), bass, drums (Max Roach)

Song Form: 32-bar AABA (“I Got Rhythm” chord progression); pre-composed intro and ending

Listen For: Pre-composed intro/outro, Parker’s virtuosic solo navigating complex changes, Max Roach’s bebop drumming (ride cymbal timekeeping), extremely fast tempo, angular melodies, clear articulation at high speed, contrafact structure

3.3 Charlie Parker — “Parker’s Mood” (1948)

Era: Bebop (1948)

from The Complete Savoy Recordings

Key Facts

1. Considered Parker’s greatest blues recording
2. Mostly improvised with only one pre-composed part
3. Alternate takes show completely different solos — demonstrates Parker’s improvisational genius
4. Slower tempo than typical bebop; more blues-based and emotional
5. Shows Parker’s range beyond fast, technical playing
6. Deep feeling and storytelling quality

Instrumentation: Alto saxophone (Parker), piano, bass, drums

Song Form: 12-bar blues; mostly improvised

Listen For: Slower tempo (contrast with typical bebop), blues feeling, mostly improvised throughout, emotional depth, Parker’s storytelling phrasing, only one pre-composed section, demonstrates range beyond pure technical virtuosity

3.4 Bud Powell — “Tempus Fugue-it”

Era: Bebop (late 1940s)

from Jazz Giant

Key Facts

1. Bud Powell = bebop pianist; heavily influenced by Art Tatum
2. Title is a play on “tempus fugit” (Latin for “time flies”) and “fugue” (musical form)
3. Demonstrates bebop piano style: right hand playing horn-like bebop lines, left hand sparse comping
4. Piano replaced stride style (heavy left hand) with lighter accompaniment
5. Shows how piano adapted to bebop aesthetic — more linear, less chordal

Instrumentation: Piano (Bud Powell), bass, drums

Song Form: Bebop composition; likely based on standard chord changes

Listen For: Right hand playing fast bebop lines like a horn, left hand sparse/rhythmic comping (not stride), incredible technique and speed, clear articulation, departure from stride piano tradition, linear rather than chordal approach

4 Additional Artists Discussed in Class

Not on the syllabus listening list but discussed in lecture — may appear on quizzes.

4.1 Dizzy Gillespie (1917–1993)

Full Name: John Birks Gillespie

Born: 1917, South Carolina; Died 1993 at age 75

Key Facts

1. Public face of bebop — very visible personality
2. Known for onstage presence: jovial, would smile and tell jokes (hence nickname “Dizzy”)
3. But very serious about his music — intellectual approach
4. Bullfrog cheeks when playing trumpet (famous visual signature)
5. Upturned trumpet horn: band mate kicked his trumpet during intermission and broke it, bending it upward; Dizzy could still play it and liked the sound, so asked trumpet maker to create special one
6. Played in very high register
7. Composed “Bebop” (1945) and many other bebop standards

Listen For (in “Bebop” 1945): Pushing forward on the beat, much faster tempo, abrupt staccato notes, horns driving more than drums/bass, thinking over phrases spanning whole measures, Dizzy’s high trumpet register

4.2 Roy Eldridge

Role: Bridge between Louis Armstrong and Dizzy Gillespie

Key Facts

1. Moved to New York in 1930
2. Lead trumpeter for Fletcher Henderson
3. Joined Gene Krupa’s band in 1941
4. “Hot trumpet sound” like Armstrong
5. Vibrato and accents make it sound like someone singing
6. Great use of dynamics
7. Not really playing in bebop language but very high range
8. Attacked ballads with more forceful approach than previous generation

Listen For (in “Rocking Chair” with Gene Krupa): Transition into bebop from big band sound, vibrato and accents creating vocal quality, great dynamics, high range, hot trumpet sound, forceful approach to ballad

4.3 Charlie Christian (guitarist)

Died: Age 25 of tuberculosis in 1942 (just as bebop was coming into its own)

Key Facts

1. First person to bring electric guitar to jazz
2. Known for long flowing melodic lines and improvisations
3. Rhythm reminiscent of the beginnings of bebop
4. Played with Kenny Clarke (drummer, considered first bebop drummer)
5. Hired by Benny Goodman as part of Goodman's integrated band

Listen For (in “Swing to Bop” with Kenny Clarke): Live recording, drums driving the beat just like guitar, the two feel really in sync and lined up, when one speeds up the other does too, electric guitar tone, flowing melodic lines

4.4 Art Tatum (pianist)

Condition: Legally blind

Key Facts

1. Incredible technique on piano, played very fast
2. Very big influence on Bud Powell (bebop pianist)
3. Stride piano technique — alternating left hand technique
4. Pushed tempos significantly
5. Syncopation with one hand while other plays strong heavy singular notes at unexpected times
6. Really light fast notes on one hand, strong notes on other

Listen For (in “I Got Rhythm” live version): Pushes tempo a lot, syncopation with one hand, really light fast notes contrasted with heavy singular notes, stride piano left hand, incredible speed and technique

4.5 Jimmy Blanton (bassist)

Died: Age 23

Band: Duke Ellington Orchestra

Key Facts

1. Big figure in the Ellington band
2. Huge sound on the bass — very resonant
3. Band had to make sacrifices (play softer) so he could be heard in beginning and end of pieces
4. If you took him away, the music would feel a lot emptier
5. Leading band with his “walking” bass line
6. Important in developing the walking bass style that became standard in bebop

Listen For (in “Jack the Bear”): Really resonant bass sound, walking bass line leading the band, band playing softer to feature bass, huge low-end presence

4.6 Lester Young (tenor saxophone)

Born: 1909, Mississippi; Died at 49

Band: Count Basie in Kansas City (1933–1940)

Sound: “Cool sound” (contrast with Armstrong/Eldridge “hot sound”)

Key Facts

1. One of Charlie Parker’s biggest influences
2. Cool sound rather than hot sound
3. Playing over phrases — telling a story through phrasing
4. Some turns and pitch bends
5. Featured on 1952 “Ad Lib Blues” with great pianist Oscar Peterson

Listen For (in “Ad Lib Blues” 1952): Cool sound, playing over phrases (not just individual notes), storytelling phrasing, turns and pitch bends, relaxed feel

5 Listening Response Template

Name, composer, and year are PROVIDED on the quiz. Focus on what you HEAR. Aim for 5 observations:

1. **Instrumentation/Ensemble** — Small combo or big band? Which instruments? Who is soloist? Electric guitar?
2. **Era/Style** — Bebop, pre-bebop, swing? What clues? (very fast tempo = bebop; contrafact structure = bebop; small combo = bebop; horns driving beat = bebop)
3. **Rhythm/Feel** — Extremely fast or slower? Pushing forward on beat? Ride cymbal timekeeping? Walking bass?
4. **Melody/Improvisation** — Angular melodies with large leaps? Clear articulation at speed? Navigating complex changes? Blues-based or chord-based? Pre-composed intro/outro?
5. **Texture/Form/Special** — Contrafact (new melody on “I Got Rhythm”)? 12-bar blues? Mostly improvised? Alternate takes completely different? Hot or cool sound? Stride piano or bebop piano?
6. **Emotion/Context** — Virtuoso display or emotional depth? Art music (not for dancing)? How does it connect to WWII context, counterculture, or rejection of entertainment model?

Template: “This piece features [ensemble type] with [soloist] as the primary voice. The style is [bebop/pre-bebop] based on [tempo, articulation, harmonic complexity]. The form is [form], evidenced by [what you hear]. A notable feature is [detail], which connects to [bebop as art music / WWII context / virtuosic demands / counterculture movement].”

6 General Understanding

6.1 Movement’s Place in History

- World War II economic hardship made big bands financially unsustainable
- Bebop was artistic rebellion: big band musicians felt their music wasn’t taken seriously
- Violent shift to “mad, furious” music reflecting cultural darkness
- Langston Hughes: “Every time a cop beats a black man with a bat, it makes a Bop sound”
- Bebop began in Harlem (Minton’s Playhouse, Clark Monroe’s Uptown House); later commercialized on 52nd Street
- Recording ban (1942–1944) meant earliest bebop was poorly documented
- Billy Eckstine’s 1944 big band was bebop all-star lineup: Parker, Dizzy, Miles, Art Blakey, Sarah Vaughan
- Small combos (4–6 musicians) replaced 15-piece big bands

6.2 Cultural Context

- Bebop as counterculture: associated with zoot suits, horn-rimmed glasses, berets, goatees
- Not danceable — deliberate rejection of swing era’s entertainment/dance function
- Fast-paced, complex, intellectual music for listening, not dancing
- Charlie Parker called “everyone’s God” by Sonny Rollins
- Parker’s heroin addiction tragically influenced a generation; he hated this legacy

- 1988 film “Bird” (Clint Eastwood, Forest Whitaker) depicts Parker’s life (depressing; only \$2 million box office)
- Bebop nickname origin: scatting sound + Langston Hughes quote about police violence

6.3 Musical Revolution

- Upper extensions of chords (9ths, 11ths, 13ths) expanded harmonic vocabulary
- Parker heard how to connect upper extensions when jamming; gave him his sound
- “Playing the changes” — navigating complex chord progressions became hallmark
- Parker made playing in all 12 keys standard for jazz artists
- Contrafact: new melodies written over “I Got Rhythm” and other standard progressions (“Ko Ko,” “Dizzy Atmosphere”)
- Drummer shifts timekeeping from bass drum to ride cymbal (lighter, more flowing feel)
- Incredible technical demands: clear articulation even at extreme speeds
- Thinking over phrases that span whole measures, not just note-to-note
- Piano shifts from stride (heavy left hand) to linear right-hand lines with sparse left-hand comping

6.4 Key Tensions

- **Art vs. Entertainment:** Bebop deliberately rejected swing’s dance function; was for listening only
- **Virtuosity vs. Accessibility:** Extreme technical demands alienated casual listeners; bebop was exclusive, not inclusive
- **Hot vs. Cool:** Eldridge/Dizzy (hot, Armstrong-influenced) vs. Lester Young (cool, melodic) — both influenced bebop
- **Economic Reality vs. Artistic Vision:** WWII economics forced small groups, but bebop musicians embraced this as artistic statement
- **Innovation vs. Documentation:** Recording ban (1942–1944) meant bebop’s birth was poorly documented
- **Parker’s Legacy:** Greatest musical innovator but tragic personal life; heroin addiction influenced generation against his wishes

6.5 Bebop’s Precursors: Five Who Helped Make a Revolution

- **Roy Eldridge (trumpet):** Bridge from Armstrong to Dizzy; hot sound, high range, vocal quality
- **Charlie Christian (guitar):** First electric guitar in jazz; long flowing melodic lines; bebop rhythm
- **Art Tatum (piano):** Incredible technique and speed; stride piano; influenced Bud Powell
- **Jimmy Blanton (bass):** Huge resonant sound; walking bass lines; featured in Ellington band
- **Lester Young (saxophone):** Cool sound; melodic/horizontal playing; major Parker influence